How it started

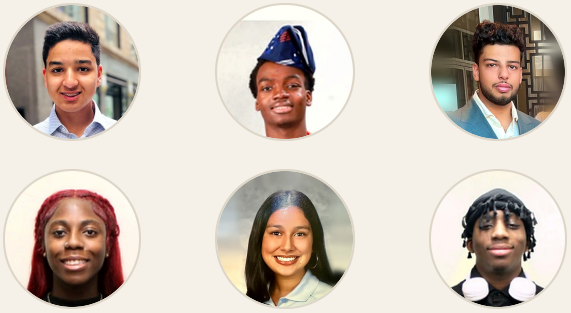
Rooted Forward was started by Zain Zaidi, a student who lives on the Near South Side and goes to school in Hyde Park. Going between the two every day, he kept running into the bubble around the University of Chicago, and how completely the city changed from one block to the next.

He went looking for why, and found redlining, restrictive covenants, and the urban renewal campaigns that cleared and rearranged these blocks on purpose.

He ran a survey at the Obama Presidential Center and talked with more than 140 people about what they had lived through and what they had been taught. The gap was far wider than he expected, including among lifelong Chicagoans and especially among young people.

So he built this. Students in three cities do the archival work and run the outreach now, and what comes out of it gets published free.

We are active in Chicago, New York, and Washington, DC.



The students who run Rooted Forward.

We could use your help

We want to partner with people and organizations who can help us bring this message to more people. If you or your organization would like our materials, we are happy to supply them.

We are also looking for people to help with archival research. You do not need experience to start.

rooted-forward.org

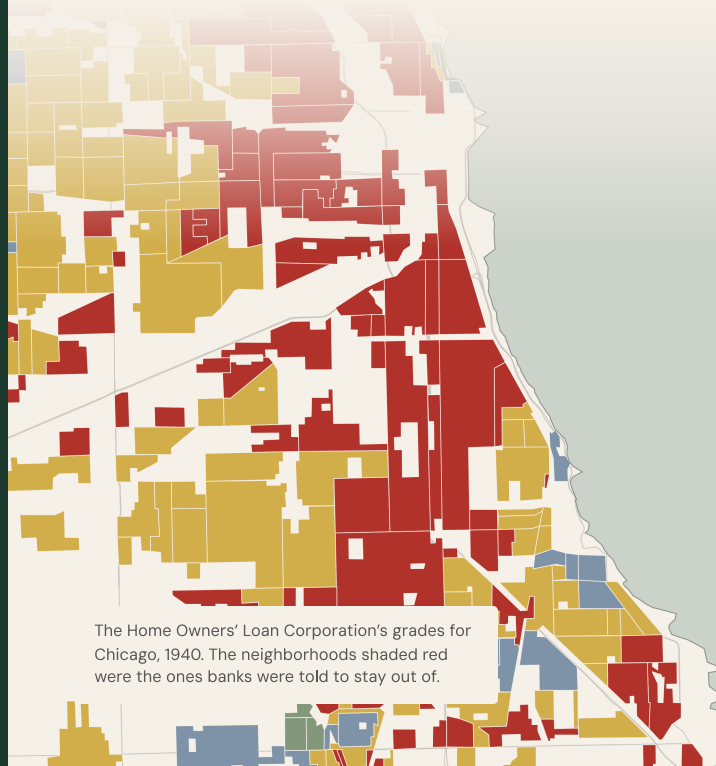
contact@rooted-forward.org

Rooted Forward

Cover map drawn from Home Owners' Loan Corporation records, 1940, by way of Mapping Inequality, University of Richmond. Streets and shoreline on both maps from U.S. Census TIGER/Line.

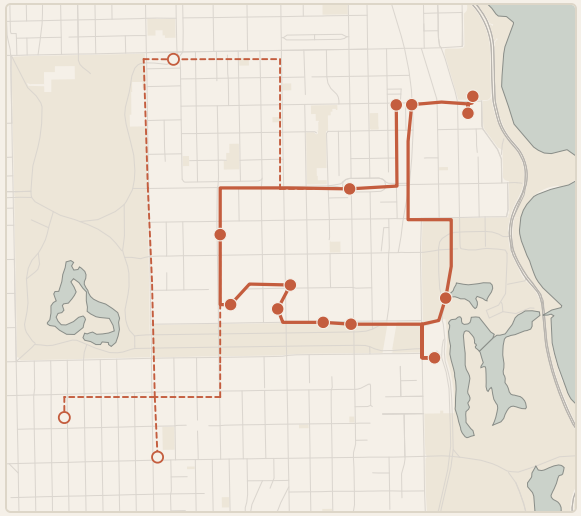
Rooted Forward

A student-run nonprofit started in Chicago. Rooted Forward raises awareness of racial inequality in cities across the United States, and works to address it through education and political advocacy.



The Home Owners' Loan Corporation's grades for Chicago, 1940. The neighborhoods shaded red were the ones banks were told to stay out of.

Ways we help



The route of Walk Hyde Park, the first tour in the app.



The plaza of the Obama Presidential Center on opening day, June 19, 2026. Photograph by AlphaBeta135, via Wikimedia Commons. CC0.



The map and its touch screen on the museum's wall in Bridgeport, September 2026. Photograph by Rooted Forward.

Self-guided walking tours

Students research one neighborhood at a time and build a tour out of what they find. It lives on the Rooted Forward app, free to walk or to read at home. Walk Hyde Park is out now.

Community outreach

We set up where people already are, like the Obama Presidential Center and neighborhood markets, and we survey and interview residents about their own block.

A museum exhibit

With the Chicago Maritime Museum, we made an exhibit on the history behind a 1931 illustrated map of Chicago. It is on view at the museum in Bridgeport.

School presentations

We present what we find to schools. We have presented at Hyde Park Academy.

Policy advocacy

We run petitions on Chicago bills that are already introduced and stuck in a committee, then hand the signatures to that committee.

New neighborhoods and cities

Rogers Park is next. Our students in New York and Washington, DC are building tours of their own cities.